

Sacred City of Kandy

The former capital of the last independent kingdom in Sri Lanka and a Buddhist pilgrimage site



The picturesque sacred city of Kandy became prominent toward the end of the 15th century as the capital of Sri Lanka. Built on a plateau surrounded by hills in the country's Central Province, it was the last capital of the Sinhala kings until it was taken over by the British in 1815.

Cultural capital

The old city of Kandy is notable for its historic buildings; outstanding architecture; and numerous Buddhist shrines, temples, and manuscripts. It is most famous, however, for the Temple of the Tooth, or Dalada Maligawa—originally part of the royal palace complex—which is believed to house the supposed left upper canine tooth of the Buddha, one of Buddhism's most venerated relics. The tooth relic is stored in a chamber, encased within layered gold caskets. According to legend, the tooth was brought to the island in the 4th century CE. Construction of the extant ornate temple, whose function was to enshrine the relic, and its associated buildings was undertaken in phases from the early 18th century. The city of Kandy, also known as Senkadagalapura, was designated a World Heritage Site in 1988. It was and remains an important place of pilgrimage for Buddhists around the world.



△ TEMPLE OF THE TOOTH

Drummers perform in the Hewisi Mandapaya, the courtyard in front of the main shrine where rituals are held to venerate the tooth relic.

▽ TEMPLE COMPLEX

The octagonal pavilion, Pattirippuwa, was built in the early 19th century by the last king of Kandy. The low, white walls in the temple complex are perforated with small carved openings.



△ PURPLE HEAVEN PALACE

Set amidst breathtaking scenery, the Purple Heaven Palace is the best-preserved palace at Wudang and an outstanding example of Ming architecture.



△ MONASTERY VILLAGE

Wudang remains a major Taoist center that attracts many pilgrims and practitioners of tai chi. The monastery village shown here provides a place of rest for adherents.

